

EDM Production Cheat Sheet (No-Jargon Edition)

Sound Shaping Tools

EQ: Turns down harsh frequencies or boosts sweet spots. Use when something sounds muddy or harsh.

Compressor: Evens out loud/quiet parts or makes sounds punchier. Use on drums, vocals, bass.

Limiter: Stops sound from going over a limit. Use on your master track.

Saturator: Adds warmth and soft distortion. Great for vocals, bass, or lifeless synths.

Volume & Movement Tools

Sidechain: Makes a sound duck when another hits (e.g., synth ducks when kick hits).

Automation: Tells knobs what to do over time (volume fades, filter sweeps, etc).

Panning: Moves a sound left or right in the mix. Helps separate layers.

LFO Tool / Volume Shaper: Makes sounds bounce without needing a kick. Great for pads and textures.

Space & Depth Tools

Reverb: Adds depth, makes things sound roomy or dreamy.

Delay: Echo effect. Good for vocals, leads, transitions.

Reverse Reverb: Reverb swell before the sound hits. Builds emotion.

Stereo Widener: Makes things sound wide. Use on pads, vocals but not bass.

Melody & Rhythm Tools

Arpeggiator: Plays chords as single notes in patterns (adds energy).

Envelope: Controls how fast a sound starts, fades, or lingers.

Filter: Removes low or high frequencies. Great for builds and drops.

Mixing Shortcuts

Too harsh? Cut 3dB around 2kHz-5kHz.

Kick disappears? Sidechain synth/bass harder.

Flat mix? Add panning and reverb/delay.

Soft drop? Layer snare/clap with white noise burst.

Muddy vocals? Use reverb/delay sends and duck them.

FX Chains Youll Actually Use

Vocal Chain: EQ Compressor De-esser Reverb (send) Delay (send)

Synth Pad: EQ Sidechain Compressor Reverb Stereo Widener

Drop Lead: Saturator EQ Delay Reverb Compressor Sidechain

Quick Terminology

Mixdown: Making sure all sounds work together.

Bus: Group of tracks sharing effects.

Send: A path to that bus.

Wet/Dry: How much of the effect you hear.

Mono/Stereo: Center vs. wide.

Low Cut/High Cut: Chop out boom or hiss.

Extras

Ask for:

- Project template
- FX chain presets for REAPER
- Mastering checklist
- Printable PDF version for your desk setup